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1 Introduction

If you had to pick the biggest copyright fight in the history of mathematics, it wouldn't be some boring plagiarism story.

It would be :

Who is the mother of calculus?

Newton said,

“I wrote the core code years ago.”

Leibniz replied,

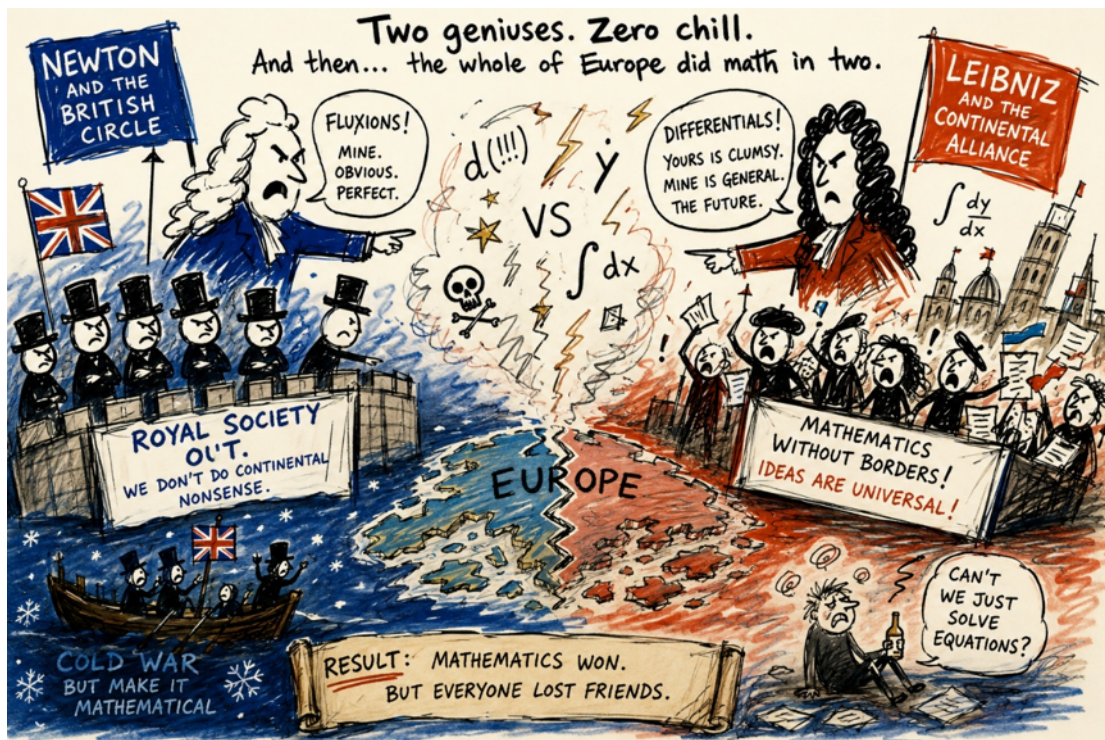
“Yeah, but I was the first to make it public. And I even designed the UI.”

Neither side would give in.

Before long, the whole European math community split into two camps.

Team Newton.

Team Leibniz.



British mathematicians even left the “group chat”. To support Newton, they basically gave Europe the academic cold shoulder.

Before the two final bosses enter the arena and start their legendary math beef, we need to ask a simple question:

why did 17th-century humans feel the urgent need to invent calculus? What kind of broken reality bugs were they trying to fix?

2 Chapter 1: The Biggest Git Conflict in Math History

If today's tech world is basically ruled by AI trending on every hot search, then in the 17th century, the real "top-tier tech project" was... the universe itself. Back then, European scientists all seemed to share one ultimate endgame quest: Figuring out how universe actually runs.

Why don't planets just randomly meet themselves into deep space? Why is the Moon just casually vibing up there like it own the place? And why do planets orbit the Sun with what looks like suspiciously perfect stability?

If you could answer those questions, congratulations , you've basically unlocked the source code of the universe .

At the time, many scientists were still running on a religious background process, so studying nature wasn't just science, it was basically trying to peek into God's dev tools without triggering a ban.

And whoever managed to crack that system first?

Yeah, they weren't just scientists anymore.

They were basically the OG "reality hackers", system administrators of physics itself.

However, if you want to crack the source code, you need a test file to run experiments on.

And luckily for them, they didn't have to look far.

They just looked up at the sky and found a perfect test dataset already running in production: the planetary motions.

That's when one of the biggest "architecture debates" in early science broke out.

Was the universe running on a Earth-server model (geocentrism), or a Sun-server model (heliocentrism)?

In other words,

was Earth the center of the entire system,

or just another node orbiting a much larger compute unit?



Back then, supporters of heliocentrism were basically getting flamed online every single day.

Because geocentrism, although extremely “bloated code,” had been patched and maintained by generations of scholars for over a thousand years. It was messy, but it still ran... more or less.

Heliocentrism, on the other hand, looked like a much cleaner and more elegant architecture. But there was a catch. You had to prove it with reliable evidence. You had to take your new system and actually predict exactly where a planet would be next.

Under this brutal test dataset, the scientific world did not believe in tears, and definitely did not care about PowerPoint presentations. What mattered was real output.

If you could accurately predict where a planet would be in the next moment, you were basically the strongest system on Earth.

If you couldn't, then no matter how beautiful your heliocentric slides looked, it was still just hype.

Just when everyone was getting completely burned out by these brutal “benchmark tests,” a German astronomer named Kepler stepped in.

He was basically the ultimate grind machine of science, the kind of person who doesn't sleep, doesn't rest, and can spend six straight years obsessing over something as "simple" as Mars' orbit.

By filling thousands of pages of scratch paper, he managed to push the new architecture forward in a critical way.

He eventually formulated the famous laws of planetary motion.

And the second law basically said this: planets sweep out equal areas in equal amounts of time.

Suddenly, the heliocentric camp felt like the sun had come out.

The core logic worked. The architecture held.

But just as mathematicians excitedly spread out their papers, ready to turn this into a clean predictive formula, everyone slowly entered a full smile-to-soul-exit moment.

Wait. The orbit... is an ellipse?

This irregular curved shape... where exactly is the formula supposed to come from?

And not only that, because mathematical tools at the time were still seriously underdeveloped, a whole pile of long-standing legacy bugs started flooding everyone's scientific To-Do list.

Curves: "I'm gonna bend a little, don't mind me."

Variables: "Who is going to find my max and min values?"

Irregular shapes: "No idea, but I swear I have a very elegant silhouette."

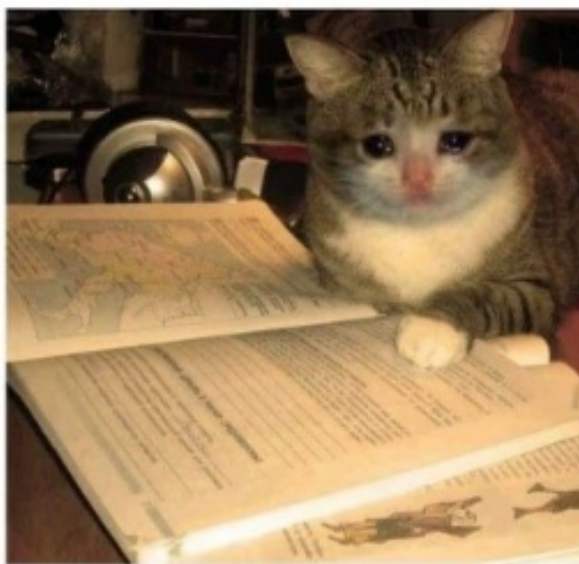
Back then, the table of contents of a thick Calculus textbook was basically what drove countless brilliant minds to exhaustion, a "10,000 why's" problem set in disguise.

It wasn't that people weren't smart enough. It was that they simply didn't have the right "programming tools" to work with.

Geometry and algebra at the time were mostly static systems, while the world they were trying to describe was full of dynamic change. Trying to handle that with existing tools was like using a plastic toy shovel to dig into the Mariana Trench. It just wasn't built for the job.

So the entire European scientific community got stuck in place, collectively screaming for a kind of god tier productivity tool that could finally handle change over time.

I am studying



But “stu” is silent

$$\log_{\text{pig}} = ?$$

3 Chapter 2: The Final 1% Patch

In an era when even calculators didn't exist, the idea that a single lone genius could suddenly "have a flash of insight" and save the world was simply unrealistic.

Faced with this universe-level bug that had effectively stalled all of humanity, the entire European mathematical community quietly formed a massive, decades-long "grind squad" and started brute-forcing the problem.

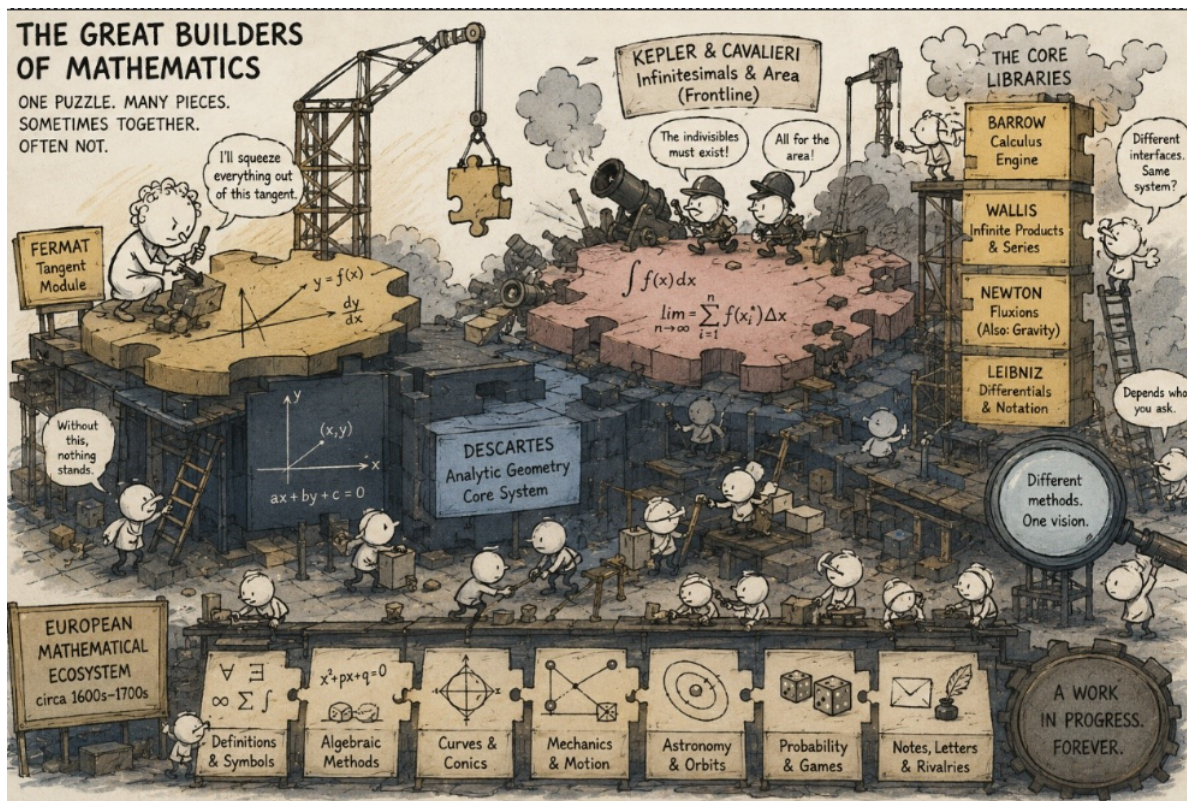
Since solo attempts weren't working, the top "hackers" of Europe naturally shifted into an open-source collaboration mode. Everyone took on different tasks, frantically contributing modules to the shared codebase, trying to build this god-tier tool through pure crowd power.

Fermat focused on one direction and essentially extracted the "tangent module" by force.

Descartes rebuilt the foundation layer and shipped analytic geometry as a core system upgrade.

Kepler and Cavalieri acted as frontline stress testers, pushing hard against the concept of infinitesimals.

Barrow and Wallis kept pushing continuous contributions and iterative patches.



It was like everyone was jointly assembling an enormous, impossible jigsaw puzzle.

By the mid-17th century, everyone rubbed their red, sleep-deprived eyes and suddenly realized in shock.

Wow The puzzle was already about 99% complete.

Everything was in place. The isolated algorithm modules were already built. All that was missing was the final step, integrating everything into a unified calculus framework.

And the next two characters to enter the scene would each, in their own genius and rivalry-driven way, finally commit the last one percent of the code.

They were

Isaac Newton,

the backend overlord of England's academic world,

and Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz,

the full stack frontend genius from Germany.